

Session 2

Product-Market Fit & Solution Validation



Find out who really wants your idea — before you build it.

Part	Topic	Time
01	Product-market fit: why it matters	5 min
02	Your target audience, and how to check you're right	8 min
03	Prototype on paper: sketches and flowcharts	6 min
04	Practice: a Lean Canvas, and your 3-minute pitch	11 min

Bring your five ideas from Session 1, paper and a pen — and line up five people to ask questions this week.

Seven words you will hear today.

Word	Plain meaning
Market	All the people who might want your product.
Product-market fit	When a clear group wants your product enough to use it, keep using it and tell others.
Target audience	The specific group you build for first.
Validation	Checking with real people that the problem is real and your idea helps.
Prototype	A quick, cheap version made to learn something: a sketch, a flowchart, a cardboard model.
Lean Canvas	A one-page plan with nine boxes that describes a product idea.
Pitch	A short talk that convinces listeners your problem matters.

Fit is when the key turns in the lock.

A beautifully made key is useless if it fits no lock. Your product is the key; people with a real problem are the lock.

In an interview, “I built it for these people, and I asked five of them” beats “I built a cool thing”.

Three signs you're getting close.

Signal	Example
They use it without being reminded	Your classmate checks the plant app every morning on their own.
They'd be disappointed if it disappeared	"Wait — you're taking the pot back? I need that!"
They tell others	"My sister wants one too."

Start narrow enough to picture one person.

Too broad	Narrow enough to build for
People with plants	Urban gardeners with a balcony and no time on weekdays
Old people	Grandparents who live alone and can't hear the doorbell from the back room
Kids	Kids aged 10–12 learning to code who get bored with screens-only lessons

Write a user profile: name, age, where they live, a typical day, and their pain point from Session 1.

Ask what they did, not what they would do.

Weak question	Better question	Why
Would you buy a self-watering pot?	Tell me about the last time one of your plants died.	Real past events, not polite guesses.
Do you like my idea?	How do you deal with this today?	Your idea must beat what they already do.
Would you use this every day?	When did this last cause you a problem?	A year ago means a small pain.

Talk to five people from your target audience. Write down what they say, in their words.

Draw it before you build it.

Film directors draw a storyboard first: changing a drawing costs nothing; reshooting costs a lot.

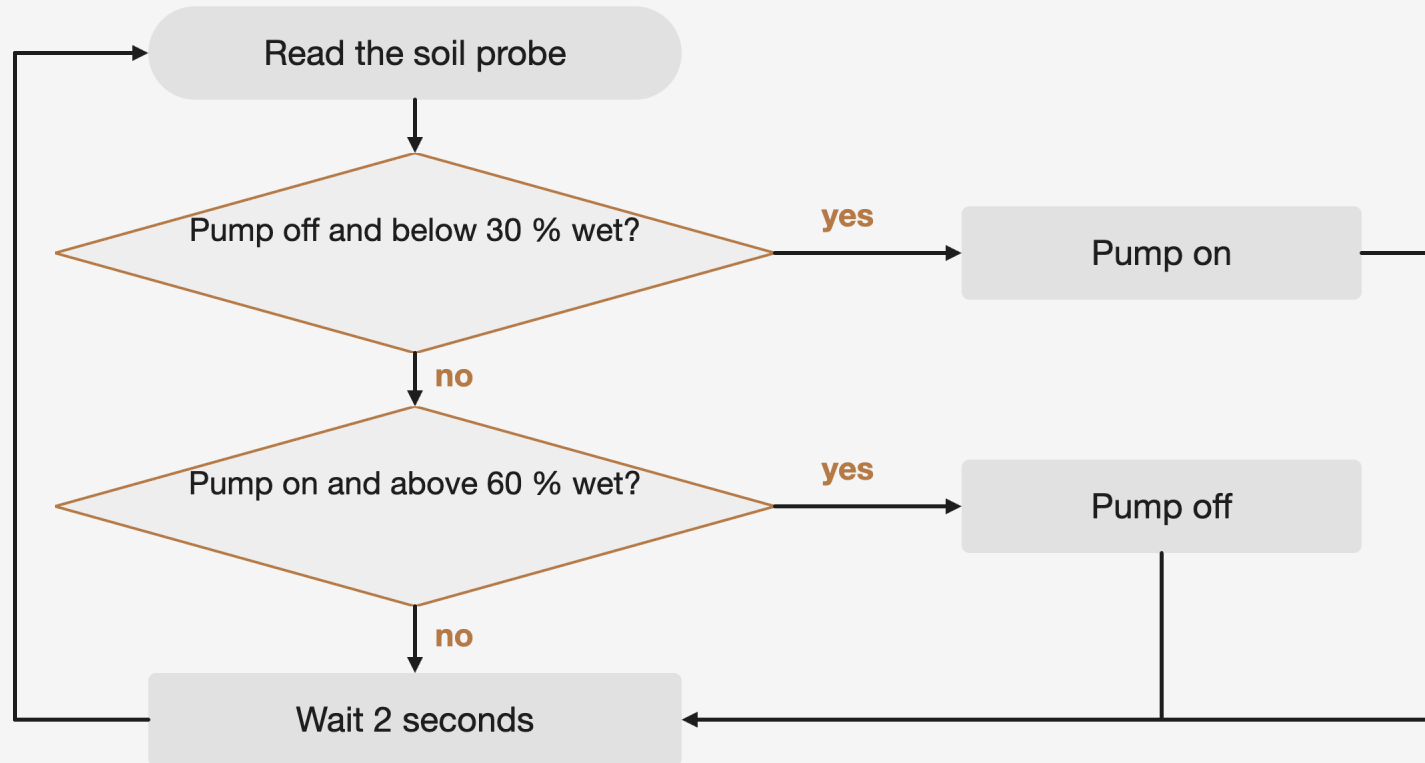
Two quick prototypes: a labelled sketch of what it looks like, and a flowchart of how it behaves.

Four shapes are enough.

Shape	Means
Oval	Start or end
Rectangle	Do something: read a sensor, switch something on
Diamond	A yes/no question — two arrows leave it
Arrow	What happens next

A flowchart is also the best thing to show an AI chat when you ask for code later.

The Smart Garden's watering logic.



A reading of -1 counts as 100 % wet, so a missing probe never starts the pump.

A whole product plan on one page, in nine boxes.

#	Box	Question it answers
1	Customer segments	Who is it for?
2	Problem	What are their top 1–3 problems?
3	Unique value proposition	One sentence: why is yours different and worth it?
4	Solution	What does it do about each problem?
5	Channels	How will people hear about it and get it?
6	Revenue streams	How could it earn money, or be funded?
7	Cost structure	What does it cost to make and run?
8	Key metrics	Which numbers show it's working?
9	Unfair advantage	What do you have that others can't easily copy?

The Smart Garden's Lean Canvas.

Box	Smart Garden
Customer segments	Students and young workers in flats with 1–5 indoor plants who travel often
Problem	Plants die during trips; they can't tell when to water; asking a neighbour is awkward
Unique value proposition	"Your plants water themselves — and only when the soil is actually dry."
Solution	Soil probe + pump with two thresholds: waters on its own, never floods
Channels	School maker fair, a demo video, plant-shop noticeboards
Revenue · Costs	Kits at [price] · board and modules [cost], pot and tubing [cost], your time
Key metrics	Plants alive after a week away; users still using it after a month
Unfair advantage	Real interviews, thresholds tuned on real plants

Choose, canvas, check.

Step	Do this
1	Choose your final concept: the Smart Garden, the Game Console, or your best Session 1 idea.
2	Fill in all nine Lean Canvas boxes. Use [] for any number you don't know yet — never invent one.
3	Interview at least three people from your target audience. Update the Problem box with what they said.
4	Prepare the 3-minute pitch.

A 3-minute problem-statement pitch.

Part	Time	Say
Hook	20 s	A real moment: “Last term, Mei came back from a competition to three dead plants.”
Problem and who	60 s	Your target audience and their pain, as your problem statement and HMW.
Evidence	40 s	What your interviews found, in their words.
Idea	40 s	Your solution in one sentence, your sketch, and the INCIPE modules it uses.
Ask	20 s	What you need next: testers, feedback, a plant to try it on.

Practise out loud with a timer. If you run over, cut features, not the problem.

Let the AI time your script.

IN THE WORKSPACE AI CHAT

Time this pitch at a normal speaking pace, and point out any sentence a 14-year-old wouldn't understand.

Then check its timing with a real stopwatch — the AI estimates; your voice decides.

“My target audience is everyone who likes plants.” Good enough?

READ THE CODE

```
Target audience:  
everyone who likes plants
```

ANSWER

Too broad

WHY

Narrow it until you can picture one person: “students in flats with a few indoor plants who travel for competitions”.

Which question gives better evidence?

READ THE CODE

A: Would you buy a
self-watering pot?

B: Tell me about the last time
one of your plants died.

ANSWER

B

WHY

It asks about something that really happened; A invites a polite “yes”.

In a flowchart, which shape asks a yes/no question?

READ THE CODE

Oval · Rectangle ·
Diamond · Arrow

ANSWER

Diamond

WHY

Two arrows leave it, one for yes and one for no.

Checkpoint 4

Which Lean Canvas box says, in one sentence, why your product is different?

READ THE CODE

Problem · Solution ·
Unique value proposition ·
Channels · Key metrics

ANSWER

UVP

WHY

The unique value proposition.

Checkpoint 5

A 3-minute pitch spends two minutes listing features. What's missing?

READ THE CODE

```
Hook ..... 10 s
Features ..... 2 min
Ask ..... 50 s
```

ANSWER

The problem

WHY

And the evidence. A problem-statement pitch spends most of its time on who has the problem and what the interviews found.

Three things to take away.

1

Product-market fit is when a clear group wants your product enough to keep using it — find that group before you build.

2

Narrow your audience until you can picture one person; check with five real people by asking what they did, not what they would do.

3

Prototype on paper — a sketch and a flowchart — then put the plan on one Lean Canvas and pitch the problem in three minutes.

Next — M5 Session 1: Storytelling & product pitching. Turning your pitch into a story people remember.